3.5 π^e or e^π?

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP II 2013, Question 1

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/13-s2-q1

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself Taking logarithms, $a^b = b^a$ is the same as $b \ln a = a \ln b$. Rearrange this so that a appears only on one side and b only on the other.

STAGE 1 The tangent through the origin

Ask yourself If $y = mx$ touches $y = \ln x$ at $x = x_0$, what two equations must hold?

STAGE 2 Lines that cut the y-axis above the origin

Ask yourself Now the line is $y = mx + c$ with $c > 0$. What are $\frac{\ln p}{p}$ and $\frac{\ln q}{q}$ in terms of m and c?

STAGE 3 Chords to the right of e

Ask yourself The chord from $(p, \ln p)$ to $(q, \ln q)$, with $e \leq p < q$, has gradient less than the gradient of the curve at p. Why? And why does that make its y-intercept positive?

Pause and try Use this, and Stage 2, to decide which is greater, π^e or e^π.

STAGE 4 Chords parallel to the tangent

Ask yourself The chord is parallel to the tangent at $(e, 1)$. Since $\ln x$ is concave, the curve lies below that tangent. Does the chord cut the y-axis above or below the origin?

Try this next

1. **Whole numbers.** Try STEP I 1988, Question 1 (step.maths.org/questions/88-s1-q1).
2. **More comparisons.** Try STEP II 2025, Question 3 (in OCR's download of the 2025 papers, www.ocr.org.uk/Images/750486-2025-past-papers.zip). It uses the graph from this section to settle more comparisons between a^b and b^a, including one where a numerical bound on e does the work.

3 A one-line proof. Use $e^x > 1 + x$ for $x \neq 0$, with $x = \frac{\pi}{e} - 1$, to prove $e^\pi > \pi^e$ directly.

Further reading

- **Eli Maor, *e: The Story of a Number*** (Princeton University Press). The history of e, including the equation $x^y = y^x$.
- **Paul Nahin, *An Imaginary Tale*** (Princeton University Press). Not only about $\sqrt{-1}$: full of curious calculations of exactly this kind.
- **Michael Spivak, *Calculus*** (Cambridge University Press). Chapter 11 covers the use of derivatives to understand the shape of graphs with complete rigour.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 3.5:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch03/pi-e-or-e-pi.html